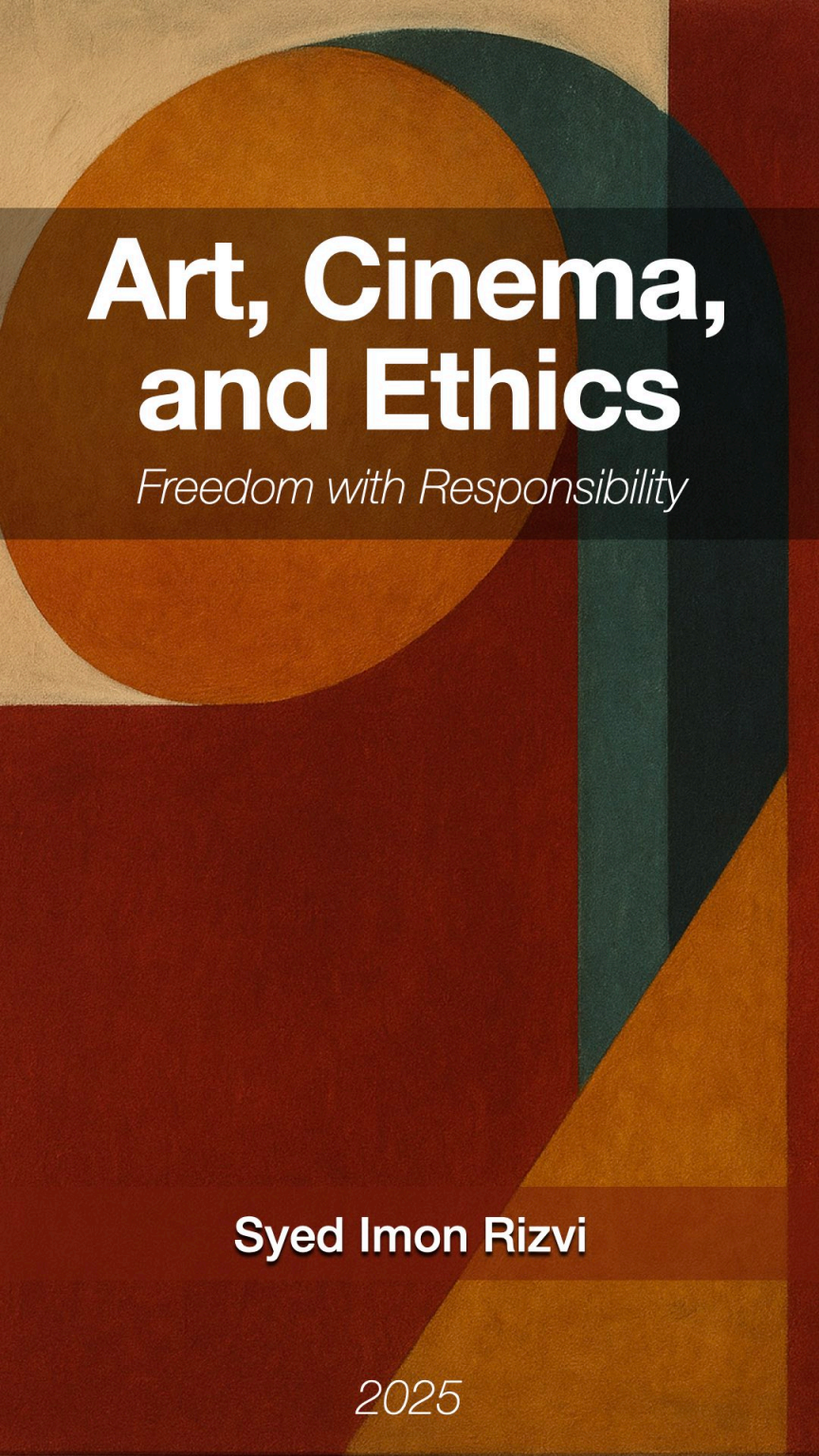




Art, Cinema, and Ethics

Freedom with Responsibility

Syed Imon Rizvi

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*In the Name of Allah,
the All-beneficent,
the All-merciful.*

Introduction

In my childhood, I heard things in certain religious gatherings that left a deep mark on me. For instance, some preachers would frighten us that anyone who watched a movie or listened to music would be punished in the grave—where snakes and scorpions would attack them for their sins. This was a terrifying image, certainly dreadful, and obviously, everyone would want to avoid such consequences. But in this, one message was clear: that all films and all music, without distinction, were dangerous.

But even at that time, I sensed a contradiction in this statement. I had seen films that carried great messages—stories of sacrifice, courage, and compassion. I had heard songs, anthems, national songs, and qawwalis that uplifted the soul, or poems that reminded one of God's greatness. So the question is, could all these films or music truly be the same as vulgar cinema, immoral songs, or meaningless entertainment? Were all forms of art being condemned equally? Unfortunately, at that time, a hardline approach was being adopted.

Later, when I saw how the Iranian Revolution dealt with cinema and

music, I observed a very different scene and atmosphere. The scholars and leaders there, instead of a blanket ban, clarified the distinction between good and bad art. They recognized that cinema could be used as a pulpit of truth, and that music, when aligned with ethical values, could elevate the spirit. For the first time, I saw that the problem was not in art itself, but in the direction in which it is used.

This booklet is about that struggle: humanity's long debate over art, ethics, religion, and freedom. From ancient philosophy to Hollywood, Bollywood, and Iran, the tension has always been the same—is art

a doorway to beauty and truth, or
a path to vulgarity and corruption?
And how should societies, parents,
and leaders respond to this
challenge?

Chapter 1: Why Media Matters

Art and cinema are more than just entertainment. They also play a role in shaping the way societies think, the values they adopt, and how younger generations envision their future. A single film can spread laughter, tears, and ideas across cultures. Music can unite people in joy or push them into despair. Media is like the cultural bloodstream—therefore, by keeping this blood pure, society can be nourished, or by filling it with immoral content, it can be poisoned.

The question is not whether we should allow or ban art, but rather: What kind of art do we want to shape our world?

Chapter 2: The Birth of Realism and Vulgarity in Cinema

Cinema began in the late 19th century as simple entertainment, but realism soon became its hallmark. Initially, while many European films depicted the raw reality of human struggle, Charlie Chaplin used comedy and silent cinema to critique poverty and injustice without any vulgarity.

Then, as the idea of realism grew, swearing, nudity, and vulgarity found their place in cinema. Hollywood was the first to normalize foul language and sexual themes (especially after the

weakening of the Hays Code restrictions in the 1960s). Bollywood and other cinemas followed suit, often blending song, dance, and melodrama with increasing boldness.

In reality, the problem was not realism itself, but the ethical use of realism.

Chapter 3: The Pursuit of Realism: A Blessing or a Curse?

Why did filmmakers embrace vulgarity and swearing? Their answer was "realism": that art must reflect life as it is. Yet, there is a paradox in this argument. Children and youth often encounter vulgarity first through films, not through real life. Thus, by showing it, art actually spreads what it claims to merely "reflect."

Realism, when handled with wisdom, exposes injustice and inspires reform. But when used without restraint, it legitimizes

harmful behaviors by presenting them as ordinary.

Chapter 4: Freedom of Expression and Its Misunderstandings

Modern societies often uphold "freedom of expression" as sacred. But freedom is often misunderstood as "absolute license." The truth is that no freedom is absolute—every freedom coexists with responsibility.

Freedom of speech ends where it incites violence or hatred. The freedom of art should end where it deliberately creates corruption or causes harm.

Humanity's failure has been in defining freedom without

responsibility. The separation of the state from ethical and spiritual values has worsened this confusion.

Chapter 5: Ethics, Truth, and Universal Values

Truth is the same everywhere—justice, compassion, and dignity are not Western or Eastern, Muslim or Christian. They are universal. Yet cultural, educational, and political differences prevent us from reaching a single conclusion.

Art can either align with this universal truth or deviate toward distortion. Only when societies place ethics at the heart of artistic creation can they achieve harmony between freedom and responsibility.

Chapter 6: The Role of Fear, Punishment, and Misguided Warnings

In many cultures, fear-based warnings were used to stop people from "bad media." Children were told that watching films or listening to music would bring snakes and scorpions into their graves. Although such narrations about punishment for sins exist, applying them blindly to all forms of art was misleading.

This "blanket approach" confused people—because good, ethical films and music also existed. However, after the Iranian Revolution, a more nuanced path

emerged: a clear distinction was presented between good and bad art, which made life easier for both audiences and creators.

Chapter 7: Leaders, Artists, and Dialogue

Art does not exist in isolation. Leaders, artists, and spiritual thinkers must remain in dialogue. Leaders protect values and long-term vision. Artists capture the mood of society. Religious thinkers provide moral anchors.

An Example from Iran: The Supreme Leader regularly meets with poets, filmmakers, artists, and actors, encouraging them to create uplifting art. This guidance also gave Iranian cinema the opportunity to create morally conscious and globally acclaimed films (e.g., *Children of Heaven*, the

films of Abbas Kiarostami, etc.).
When dialogue, connection, or
conversation is absent, art risks
either becoming propaganda or
getting trapped in the chaos of
vulgar themes.

Chapter 8: Modern Challenges: Streaming Platforms and Globalization

Today, Netflix and other streaming services are shaping global culture. While they provide opportunities for diverse voices, they are also causing the spread of vulgarity on an unprecedented scale.

Common trends include:

- Normalizing swearing and crude humor among both youth and elders.
- Presenting sexuality casually.
- Normalizing same-sex relationships, which conflicts with many cultures and religions.

These challenges must be discussed not with fear or censorship alone, but through stronger ethical filters, parental guidance, and community-produced alternatives.

Chapter 9: The Responsibility of Families, Communities, and Educators

The foremost responsibility lies with families and communities. Parents should strive to enhance their children's intellectual and logical reasoning and prove such topics to be irrational and unethical on an intellectual and logical basis. Parents must also filter content and discuss it with their children. Educators must teach media literacy, helping students analyze what they see.

Communities must organize cultural alternatives: poetry

gatherings, theater, film screenings, and workshops that promote beauty without vulgarity. Over-restriction creates rebellion, while over-freedom creates chaos. Therefore, success lies in balance and consistent, logical guidance.

Chapter 10: Religious and Spiritual Guidance in Shaping Art and Media

Art has always been connected to spirituality—from sacred music to calligraphy and epic poetry. Religion need not suffocate creativity; rather, it can be a great source of inspiration. As we have seen in Iran, films about Prophet Joseph (PBUH), the Companions of the Cave, Lady Mary (PBUH), and the Messenger of God (PBUH) achieved remarkable success. Recently, an anthem like "Salam Farmandeh" sparked an incredible global phenomenon that left the entire world astonished.

Historically, Christianity produced the art of Michelangelo and Bach.

Islam produced poets like Rumi, Saadi, and Iqbal.

After 1979, Iran created a cinema that balanced realism with ethics.

Spirituality provides direction: art should honor truth, justice, and compassion while avoiding corruption and vulgarity.

Chapter 11: Toward an Ethical Framework for Global Media

The global media environment demands shared principles:

- Freedom with responsibility.
- Truthfulness and honesty.
- Respect for human dignity.
- Cultural and religious sensitivity.
- Positive role modeling for youth.
- Collaboration between governments, artists, and spiritual leaders.
- Encouragement of beauty and hope.

This framework balances universal ethics with local cultural voices.

Chapter 12: Conclusion: Freedom, Responsibility, and the Future of Art

Art is a mirror of humanity. But we must decide what reflection we want to see: one of vulgarity and despair, or one of dignity and hope.

Freedom is precious, but without responsibility, it becomes destructive. Responsibility is shared—among artists, leaders, educators, parents, and communities.

If guided with wisdom, art can be one of humanity's greatest treasures: it can play its role as a force for truth, compassion, and

beauty. The choice is now ours—
because our next generation
depends on it.